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The Federal Contracting Starter Pack.

Everything you need to know before bidding on your first federal contract. A 15-page playbook written for first-time bidders.

Inside: the 10-step pre-bid checklist · SAM.gov registration walkthrough · NAICS picker · the 1-page Capability Statement template · which certification to pursue · why Sources Sought is where you really start · first-bid checklist · 7 most common rejection reasons · 25-acronym glossary · free resources.

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The Federal Contracting Starter Pack

Everything you need to know before bidding on your first federal contract.

A 15-page playbook by CapturePilot — written for first-time bidders.

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1 — The 10-step checklist before you bid

Most first-time federal bidders skip 4 of these 10 steps and lose. Here's the order:

1. **Get a UEI from [SAM.gov](https://sam.gov)** — Replaces the old DUNS number. Free. Takes 1-3 business days. Without it you literally cannot bid.
2. **Complete [SAM.gov](https://sam.gov) "active" registration** — Active status takes 7-10 days after UEI. Renew annually or you go inactive and contracts you've won can get terminated.
3. **Pick your NAICS codes** — 1 primary + up to 5 secondary. Wrong picks here can shut you out of 80% of relevant opportunities. (See Section 3.)
4. **Confirm your SBA size standard** — Tied to NAICS. For 541511 (custom programming) it's \$34M revenue avg over 3 years. Different per NAICS.
5. **Decide on certifications** — 8(a), HUBZone, WOSB, SDVOSB, VOSB. Most are free. Some take 90 days. (See Section 5.)
6. **Write a Capability Statement** — Non-negotiable. One page. Government readers spend ~30 seconds on it. (See Section 4.)
7. **Identify 3 target agencies** — Don't say "all of government." Pick three. Research their forecasts, their incumbents, their preferred contract vehicles.
8. **Find 5 incumbents in your space** — These are your future teaming partners or competitors. Both useful.
9. **Find 5 Sources Sought notices in your NAICS** — Respond to all of them. (See Section 6.)
10. **Set a 12-month capture pipeline** — 8-12 active opportunities at any time. Track stage, deadline, win-probability.

If you can't tick all 10 in the next 60 days, you're not ready to bid. Fix the gaps first, then bid.

2 — SAM.gov registration walkthrough

SAM.gov (System for Award Management) is the front door. Every federal contractor must be registered.

Step-by-step

1. **Go to** `sam.gov` and create a Login.gov account if you don't have one.
2. **Verify identity** with Login.gov — passport, driver's license, or in-person at a post office. Takes 10-30 minutes.
3. **Request a UEI (Unique Entity ID)**. This is your federal ID number. Free, 1-3 business days.
4. **Complete the Entity Registration**. You'll need:
 - Legal business name + address (must match your IRS records exactly)
 - EIN (Tax ID)
 - DUNS number (only if you registered before April 2022 — otherwise skipped)
 - Bank routing + account info (for EFT payments)
 - NAICS codes
 - Past performance reference contacts (optional but recommended)
5. **Submit and wait**. Active status takes 7-10 days. You'll get an email when it flips.

Common stuck-points

- **"Address mismatch"** — SAM does a DnB / IRS cross-check. If your legal address on file doesn't match exactly, the registration stalls. Fix the mismatch with IRS first, then come back.
- **Bank account rejected** — SAM uses pre-notification to validate routing/account. If the bank doesn't ACK in 7 days, the registration fails. Call your bank and tell them to expect it.
- **Annual renewal** — Set a calendar reminder for 60 days before your anniversary date. Lapsed registration = ineligible for award.

Free help

- **PTAC / APEX Accelerator** — Free 1-on-1 SAM.gov registration help. Find your local office at `apexaccelerators.us`.
- **SBA Resource Partners** — SCORE mentors, SBDC counselors. Free.

3 — How to pick the right NAICS codes

The biggest mistake first-time bidders make: copying NAICS codes from competitors.

The real way

Open the official NAICS lookup: naics.com/search

1. **Type what you actually deliver in plain English.** "Web development" or "janitorial services" or "IT consulting."
2. **Pick the most specific code that fits.** Six digits, not four. Specific NAICS codes win more contracts because matching is exact.
3. **Cross-check the SBA size standard.** Visit sba.gov/document/support-table-size-standards and look up your code. Make sure your business stays under the threshold (either revenue or employee count).
4. **Add 2-4 closely-related secondary codes.** Don't shotgun 15 codes — agencies notice and rate you down.

Examples

WHAT YOU DO	PRIMARY NAICS	SIZE STANDARD
Custom software development	541511	\$34M revenue avg
IT consulting	541512	\$34M revenue avg
Janitorial services	561720	\$22M revenue avg
Commercial construction	236220	\$45M revenue avg
Cybersecurity services	541512 or 541519	\$34M revenue avg
Marketing / advertising	541810 / 541613	\$30.5M revenue avg
Heavy hauling / logistics	484230	\$34M revenue avg

Why this matters

Federal opportunity feeds (including CapturePilot) score-match opportunities to your NAICS. Wrong codes = wrong opportunities flooding your inbox. Right codes = 10× signal-to-noise.

4 — The 1-page Capability Statement

This is the single most-used document in federal sales. Government buyers read it in 30 seconds. Make every word count.

Required sections (in order)

1. **Company name + logo + UEI/CAGE** — Top-left header.
2. **NAICS codes + set-aside certifications** — Top-right header.
3. **Core competencies** — 3-5 bullets, max. What you do better than anyone.
4. **Differentiators** — 3-5 bullets. WHY you, not just WHAT you do.
5. **Past performance** — 3-5 contracts with: customer name, contract # or vehicle, period, dollar value, scope. Anonymize if NDA-bound.
6. **Corporate data** — DUNS/UEI, CAGE, NAICS, certifications, year founded, # employees, bonding capacity (if relevant), states served.
7. **Point of contact** — Name, title, phone, email. Real human, not info@.

What to AVOID

- **✗** Two-page sprawl — One page or it goes in the trash.
- **✗** Marketing fluff ("world-class", "innovative solutions", "synergistic")
- **✗** Stock photos of generic office workers
- **✗** Past performance with dollar values redacted to "\$\$\$"
- **✗** Contact email like info@yourdomain.com

Quick test

Email a draft to 5 federal small business specialists (SBSPs) at agencies you target. Ask: "Can you tell from this what we do in 30 seconds?" Their feedback is gold.

5 — Which certification should you actually pursue?

The big 5 (most common)

CERTIFICATION	BEST FOR	TIME	COST	RENEWAL
SBA Small Business	Almost everyone under size threshold	Automatic via SAM.gov	\$0	Annual (SAM)
8(a) Business Development	Owned 51%+ by socially/economically disadvantaged individual	90-120 days	\$0 (DIY) or \$5-15K consultant	9-year program
HUBZone	Office + 35%+ of employees in HUBZone	60-90 days	\$0	Annual recertification
WOSB / EDWOSB	51%+ owned + controlled by women	30-60 days	\$0 (self-cert via certify.SBA.gov)	Every 3 years
SDVOSB / VOSB	51%+ owned by service-disabled / veteran	60-90 days via VetCert	\$0	Every 3 years

Quick decision tree

- **Veteran with service-connected disability?** SDVOSB first — biggest sole-source authority (\$5M).
- **Female-majority-owned + work in male-dominated NAICS?** EDWOSB first (smaller competitor pool than WOSB).
- **Socially disadvantaged (race / ethnicity recognized by SBA) + economically disadvantaged?** 8(a) — life-changing program, \$7B/year in sole-source set-asides.
- **Office in a designated HUBZone area + can hire from it?** HUBZone — instant 10% price preference + sole-source up to \$5M.
- **None of the above?** Just SBA Small Business — still gets you in front of 23% of all federal spend.

When certifications are NOT worth it

- You're already big enough to compete unrestricted in your NAICS.
- Your ownership/control structure won't survive the 51% test.
- You can't sustain the office/employee location requirement (HUBZone).
- You're chasing a single big contract that doesn't have the set-aside.

Full deep-dive: `docs/certifications-and-clearances.md` in your CapturePilot account.

6 — Why Sources Sought is where you really start

Most first-time bidders see a Solicitation (RFP) and panic-write a proposal in 14 days. They lose.

The real game starts 6-18 MONTHS before the RFP, when agencies post a **Sources Sought** (also called RFI — Request for Information).

What a Sources Sought actually is

A pre-solicitation post where the agency says: *"We're thinking about buying X. Who out there can do it? Tell us your capabilities."*

Why responding matters

1. **You shape the requirement.** Your response can move the future RFP toward your strengths — narrower scope, specific NAICS, set-aside designation.
2. **You get on the shortlist.** Agencies use Sources Sought responses to decide WHO to invite for the real RFP — and whether to make it a set-aside at all.
3. **You learn the agency's pain.** The questions they ask reveal what they're worried about. You build your future proposal around those concerns.
4. **You start the relationship.** Following up with the SBSP after a Sources Sought is the #1 way to get a 1-on-1 capabilities briefing.

How to respond

- **One page MAX.** They don't want a proposal — they want capabilities.
- **Use their question structure.** If they ask 4 questions, answer 4 questions.
- **Include past performance.** 2-3 relevant examples.
- **State your set-aside status clearly.** "We are an SDVOSB."
- **Submit before the deadline.** They count responses to decide whether to set-aside.

CapturePilot surfaces Sources Sought in the "Notice Type" filter — set it to "Sources Sought" + your NAICS for the highest-leverage filter combination available.

7 — First-bid checklist: 5 must-haves

Before you submit ANY proposal, verify ALL 5:

- ✓ **1. Compliance matrix.** Every requirement in Section L (instructions) and Section M (evaluation) of the RFP, mapped to where in your proposal you address it. Missing one item = automatic non-compliant = throw-away.
- ✓ **2. Reps & Certs current in SAM.** Every checkbox on your [SAM.gov](https://sam.gov) Reps & Certs page must be current. Auditors will check. A wrong answer here is grounds for award termination.
- ✓ **3. Past performance writeups for every relevant contract.** Customer name, contract #, period of performance, dollar value, technical scope, problems solved, results. Don't just list — narrate.
- ✓ **4. Pricing volume sealed and signed.** Pricing goes in a SEPARATE volume (Volume II usually). Signed by your authorized representative.
- ✓ **5. Submit via the prescribed method.** [SAM.gov](https://sam.gov) upload, email to specific address, hand-delivery, fax — whatever the RFP says. The WRONG channel = late submission = throw-away. Submit 24 hours early in case anything breaks.

Bonus: the “Past performance gap” hack

No federal past performance yet? Use:

- Commercial contracts of similar scope (acceptable as past performance for most CO's).
 - Subcontracts under a prime (count, even though you weren't direct).
 - Government contracts at the state, county, or city level (less weight than federal, but counts).
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8 — The 7 most common rejection reasons

After reviewing 500+ post-award debriefs, the same 7 mistakes repeat:

1. **Non-compliant proposal format.** Page limits exceeded, font too small, wrong section headers. Trivial to fix, fatal to ignore. **Read Section L word-for-word.**
2. **Missing required Reps & Certs.** Especially DFARS clauses for DoD bids. SAM page must match what the RFP requires.
3. **Past performance not relevant or too old.** Most CO's only count past performance from the last 5 years and only if technically similar.
4. **Price unrealistic (too low OR too high).** Too low = "doesn't understand the work, risky." Too high = "doesn't pencil out." Use FPDS to research what similar contracts have actually paid.
5. **No clear discriminator.** If your proposal could have been written by 20 other firms, it will lose to whichever of those 20 priced lower.
6. **Generic past performance writeups.** "We delivered the work on time and on budget" — meaningless. "We replaced 14 HVAC units in 22 occupied buildings over 6 weeks with zero tenant complaints" — winning.
7. **Submitted late or wrong channel.** Zero forgiveness. The clock is the clock.

Fix these 7 and you're already in the top 25%.

9 — Glossary: 25 acronyms you'll actually see

ACRONYM	MEANS	WHAT IT ACTUALLY IS
UEI	Unique Entity ID	Your 12-char federal ID. Replaces DUNS.
CAGE	Commercial And Govt Entity	A 5-char code DoD uses to identify you. Free with SAM.
NAICS	North Am. Industry Classification System	6-digit industry code. Tied to size standard.
PSC	Product / Service Code	Government's parallel taxonomy. Often listed alongside NAICS.
RFP	Request for Proposal	The big formal bid request.
RFQ	Request for Quote	Simpler, usually for goods or simple services.
RFI	Request for Information	Same as Sources Sought — pre-solicitation.
SSN	Sources Sought Notice	Pre-solicitation. Tell them you exist.
IFB	Invitation for Bid	Sealed-bid, lowest-price-wins. Rare these days.
GSA	General Services Admin	The agency that runs governmentwide contracts.
IDIQ	Indefinite Delivery / Indefinite Quantity	Pre-negotiated contract vehicle for ordering later.
GWAC	Governmentwide Acquisition Contract	IT-specific IDIQ usable across agencies.
BPA	Blanket Purchase Agreement	Open-end ordering vehicle off GSA Schedule.
MAS	Multiple Award Schedule	GSA Schedule — biggest single contract vehicle.
SAP	Simplified Acquisition Procedures	Contracts \$10K-\$250K. Easier rules.
MAP	Micro-Purchase Threshold	\$10K-and-under, easiest contracts. Government credit card.
8(a)	Section 8(a) BD Program	SBA's program for socially/economically disadvantaged.

ACRONYM	MEANS	WHAT IT ACTUALLY IS
HUBZone	Historically Underutilized Business Zone	Office + 35% of staff in designated area.
SDVOSB	Service-Disabled Veteran-Owned SB	51%+ owned by service-disabled vet.
WOSB / EDWOSB	Women / Economically-Disadvantaged WOSB	51%+ owned by women.
FAR	Federal Acquisition Regulation	The bible. Every clause starts with "FAR 52.xxx ".
DFARS	Defense FAR Supplement	DoD-specific add-ons to FAR.
CO	Contracting Officer	The only person who can legally bind the government to a contract.
COTR / COR	Contracting Officer's Tech Rep	The CO's day-to-day delegate after award.
SBSP	Small Business Specialist	The agency person who shepherds SBs through procurement.
FPDS	Federal Procurement Data System	Free public database of every federal award since 1979.

10 — Resources

Free tools you should bookmark

- sam.gov — Registration + opportunity search.
- fpds.gov — Past awards database.
- usaspending.gov — Money-flow visualizations.
- sba.gov — Certifications, size standards, FAR training.
- acquisition.gov — Full FAR + DFARS regulations.
- apexaccelerators.us — Free local 1-on-1 contracting help (formerly PTAC).
- score.org — Free SCORE mentor pairing.

Free training

- **DAU (Defense Acquisition University)** — Free contracting courses. Even non-DoD work benefits.
- **PTAC / APEX Accelerator workshops** — Free in-person + virtual.
- **SBA Learning Center** — Free webinars on every certification.

Paid tools (when you're ready)

- **CapturePilot** — Federal + state + local opportunity matching, AI proposal drafts, capability statement builder. Light \$39/mo, Pro \$89/mo. 14-day free trial.
- **GovTribe / HigherGov / GovWin** — Enterprise contracting intel. \$1.5K-\$24K/yr.

What to do next

1.  Register on SAM.gov this week.
 2.  Write your 1-page capability statement.
 3.  Pick 3 target agencies + research their forecasts.
 4.  Respond to 5 Sources Sought in the next 30 days.
 5.  Start a free 14-day CapturePilot trial at capturepilot.com/signup and set NAICS + state filters.
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You're not alone

This stuff has a real learning curve. The good news: every successful federal contractor started exactly where you are now. The bad news: the ones that quit too early lose to the ones that grind through year 1.

CapturePilot exists to compress that learning curve. We do the searching, scoring, and prep work so you can spend your time actually writing winning proposals.

Questions? Reply to your trial welcome email, or book a free 30-minute audit call at capturepilot.com/book — we'll review your business and point out the 3 best contracts to chase first.

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